

February

3

1982 Heavy lifting

The Russian heavy-transport helicopter Mil Mi-26, piloted by a crew of two, lifted a mass of 56,770 kg (125,156 lb) up to a height of 2,000 m (6,560 ft) in Moscow. This was the heaviest load ever lifted by helicopter.



Also on this day

1870 The 15th Amendment to the US Constitution was ratified (formally approved), ensuring that Black men had the right to vote.

1966 The Soviet Union's *Luna 9* touched down on the Moon. It was the first spacecraft to survive landing on the lunar surface.

1972 The deadliest blizzard in recorded history began in Iran, killing 4,000 people and destroying about 200 villages.

1931

Earthquake in Hawke's Bay

The worst natural disaster in New Zealand's history, the Hawke's Bay earthquake, shook the east coast of North Island, killing 258 people.



Born this day

1790 Gideon Mantell, British palaeontologist. While reconstructing a fossil, he realized it belonged to an enormous extinct animal, which he named *Iguanodon*.

1970 Warwick Davis, British actor. He has appeared in various roles in the *Star Wars* films. Born with a rare form of dwarfism, he co-founded the Little People UK charity.

1995 Piloting in space

US astronaut Eileen Collins became the first female Space Shuttle pilot when she flew the *Discovery* close to Russia's *Mir* space station. The mission lasted eight days.

